Lover

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53400433.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Arranged Marriage, Secret Identity, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Catra thinks Adora is dead, Past established Relationship, Catra thinks She-Ra killed Adora, Nobody knows Adora is She-Ra besides Bow and Glimmer, Catra is very angry, Angst, The whole series has a happy ending, But this work is just angst for now, sorry - Freeform, Adora loves Catra so very much, Love Confessions, Hate to Love, Not Actually Unrequited Love, heavy make outs, No spicy times on this one, Poor Catra give her a breath, Also poor Adora someone hug her please, Adora is so much better at She-Ra here, She-Ra and Adora are the same person btw, No magical spirit living inside Adora or nothing like that, Just a depressed girl with magic powers on steroids, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), They both do, Marriage of Convenience, Kisses as an apology, Other Additional Tags to Be Added

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Series:
Part 1 of Ruins of War

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by StarryNap

Summary

'Night runs them by and they love each other, they die for each other. And they are a whole world apart'

Or, Catra marries She-Ra, General of the Alliance and Goddess of Etheria's old world, to join the Horde and the Alliance against Horde Prime's forces. Except that Catra doesn't know who She-Ra really is, as she thinks She-Ra killed Adora in Thaymor three years ago. But the matters of the heart are complicated as are the strings that join soulmates and they'll guide Catra for paths she couldn't even phantom before

Or, Arranged Marriage/Secret Identity AU. Angst ensues.

Notes

Hello and welcome to this new, toasty and warm angst series meant to rip you apart completely and then pull you back together, because that's what we do in this house!

As the tags say, this series is meant to have a happy ending, but this work in particular is just straight up angst, so sorry about that!

Please feel free to leave a comment, kudos, questions or bookmarks! I'll try my best to catch up on answering all of your lovely comments. Also, I left you some (kind of long) notes in the end about the lore of this story so you can get a better grip of the events this story is taking place in.

Hope you enjoy my scribbles! Be good! ♡

See the end of the work for more notes

I. Lover

I wanna cry and I wanna love

But all my tears have been used up

On another love, another love

All my tears have been used up

– **Another Love,** *Tom Odell*



The door of the chamber slams against the wall with a force so strong that the soft lilac wallpaper tears and crumbles slightly, dust and debris falling over the polished floors in silence. Absently, Catra hopes the door close back down with the same force, loud enough to be heard across the entire fucking Bright Moon palace; heavy enough that it makes the very pillars to tremble and maybe even crumble into pieces under her feet, burying marble and luxury and dry blood all of her pain right under her feet.

The door doesn't slam back closed. By the time Catra has crossed the too warm bedroom towards the open arch of the balcony, the heavy door has already lost inertia and simply swings back to place with a muted rush of breeze. Catra's rage is screaming inside her ears, the rush of boiling blood that swirls inside her head and down her closed palms, but her ears twitch down, waiting for the click of the door, waiting for the privacy of loneliness, of abandonment, of sorrow and misery. If she waits long enough, she might just throw herself off the balcony rail and be done with it already, be back with *her* , finally.

But no clicking sound comes nor the acid and corrosive silent after it. Instead, there are steps, light as fresh breeze through fresh cut grass, and the characteristically smell of electricity and *magic* that Catra has come to identify as *her.* Her. She-Ra.

She-Ra has never stepped a foot inside Catra's bedroom, inside *their* bedroom. She has never walked through these floors or stood in front of the open windows. She has never slept in Catra's bed, next to Catra's side, against Catra's skin. Not even that first night; that night when Catra traded herself to form an alliance with the people she hated the most; that rotten gorgeous night when she signed blood stained peace to try and win the war. That night when they tied a knot around her and She-Ra's joined hand and made her call her *wife.* Not that night, not the after, not ever.

And it makes Catra want to scream because how dare she, how dare she to walk inside this chamber and look so perfectly in place with everything that it's here and yet at the same time look like she doesn't belong here. How dare she walk with her gold and marble white soles and her soft skin that shines like a star and her sun poured hair. With her hands and her arms and her skin without a trace of war or scars on them. She is not her, she could never be her. She could never be Adora, Catra's Adora.

Catra's Adora hair wasn't sun or gold but wheat, something nurturing, something full of the hope of life, ash colored sometimes when the winter rolled in the Fright Zone, and honey copper during the summer under the red light of the poisoned Fright Zone. Adora's skin wasn't stardust but warm like the honey they had stolen from Weaver's chamber when they were seven; something sweet, something alive. Catra's Adora eyes weren't crystal cut and blue but gray, like the sky they got to see at the top of their spot, beyond the cloud of crimson fog. She wasn't regal and perfect, back straight and face serene untouchable; she was messy and nervous, always trying so hard, always stretching herself too much; always tripping on her own feet and giggling when nobody but Catra saw her. Catra's Adora wasn't quiet, tense, held at a distance from Catra at all times as if she was indifferent or more powerful or… ashamed.

No.

Catra's Adora kissed Catra in the back of the barracks when they were sixteen – shy and damp and nervous, and then every single

day after that. Between drills in dark corners and at early hours of the dawn inside empty storage rooms and next to the rumbling motors of machines.

Catra´s Adora slipped above Catra´s thin blanket in their shared bunk bed at seventeen and laid very-very still until everyone around them was asleep. And after, between other´s snores and the quiet drip of cold water from the roof, she raked her nails over Catra´s back and listened to her breath the entire night, at arm's length the entire time, both of them awake yet incapable of getting closer.

Catra´s Adora snuck at midnight inside Catra´s stall on the empty showers´chamber when they were eighteen, sharing the reduced space under the cold spray of water; and Adora wrapped her arms around Catra´s shoulders, her bare chest against Catra´s naked back, and held her close to her soaked body, just like this and nothing else but palms against palms and a nose against a neck. They didn't move from that position for a long time, quietly and silently basking on the feeling of the other´s skin against theirs in a way they weren't allowed to do when everyone else was awake and the dooming eyes of shadows hovered over them.

Catra´s Adora got nervous at nineteen, ears bright red after their first, *and only* , Horde lesson about what sex was and all the ways anyone that was caught practicing it would be painfully punished because that place wasn't meant for tender or vulnerable things. Because, for the Horde, it was something that takes from you, something that taints your training and distracts your mind, not that gives you something beautiful in return. Adora got quiet in the months after, content in cradling Catra inside her arms on stolen moments in empty closets, but cadets *talk,* and they whisper among each other and snicker, about prohibited things and warm things in dark corners. And Catra knew something was building up, that something was going to happen as well as Adora did, when they linked their pinkies under the tables of the dining halls or stared at each other in silence at night, something that was meant to be sooner or later not to fulfill some curiosity but

because they adored each other in ways the Horde could never taint and that, that would be theirs.

One late night, months after, Adora got clumsy, giddy and tender as she held Catra´s wrist and guided her silently around the abandoned vents of the empty buildings of the Fright Zone until they reached what she was looking for. A tiny room filled with warmth tucked behind the boiled rooms where Adora made love to Catra for the first time over stolen blankets. First love, tumultuous love, sweet love. Softly, honeysuckle, trembling fingers and damp tongue and inexperienced happiness hushed between laughter and whispered kisses. Stroking all of her petals until Catra was blooming against her, intoxicating and addictive, her arms around her neck and her back arched between her forearms; and after, curling around each other's damp and worn out bodies like praying hands. And then again. And again. And again … ….

Catra´s Adora never told her she loved her because none of them ever learnt the words, not here on this place where nothing beautiful ever grew, but Catra knew. She knew, deep inside the marrow of her bones and the blood running in her body. She knew in Adora´s laughter against her cheeks and shared smiles full of secret meaning and her hand holding hers, hidden under the blanket. She knew, on Adora´s mouth against her lips and her calloused fingers from the exhausting drills drawing circles on the low of her back. Even when everything inside that place tried to pull them apart, Adora was a constant, an anchor the the world, the beating of her heart and the warmth of her skin were the only things Catra was always sure off.

But life is not fair and it takes from you and sometimes your time runs out before you can barely begin to adore it. A week later, still with the shadow of Catra´s kisses painted under the neck of her shirt and the low curve of her hips, Catra´s Adora got promoted to Force Captain, and she stole a skiff to make Catra laugh and she got herself lost in the woods for too many minutes because she was a knucklehead and stupidly brave. And at night, nervous for something Cstrs couldn't understand, she begged Catra to stay

home because she couldn't bear to see her punished by Weaver anymore, not for something Adora had done, and she disappeared with the promise of coming back in the morning. And Catra didn't follow, too wrapped inside their shared trust and the breathless kiss Adora gave her before leaving, too scared of what they would find outside this rotten comfort to follow her.

Catra found her again among smoke and fire with her lungs filled with the fear of having lost her, of what Weaver might do to Adora, to both of them if she knew Adora wants to *leave.* With rage running down her veins and her hands closed in fists and they fought.

“Please come with me, Catra,” Adora begged, soiled in dirt and sweat, her shivering hands cradling Catra's face. “I can leave you there, please come.”

“Why would you leave me at all?” Catra yelled, slapping her hand away, because it was the only way she could hide the tears burning in her eyes. “Why can't you just stay?”

“Because it's wrong, Catra!”

They fought like they had never done before with sore throats and ashed cheeks, before getting separated again by the nearby explosions all around Thaymor and glitter in the air and strange nets tangling in Catra's limbs, powerless as she saw Adora being dragged away from her again.

And then Catra´s Adora died. Slaughtered. Buried. Gone.

Adora with her wheat hair and her gray eyes and her smile. That Adora that wasn't the Horde’s Force Captain or Weaver's golden child but Catra's Adora that didn't even know what she wanted but that did it all anyway with her entire heart. That Adora who was stupid and brilliant and irresponsibly brave. That Adora who was Catra's entire world and best friend, who kissed Catra at sixteen and held her at seventeen and loved her in soul and body at nineteen. Adora who gave herself to Catra and to whom Catra

gave herself in return. Adora who Catra loved. Adora whose Horde shirt gave her away immediately. She was there one moment, among smoke and sparks of fire, with heavy pants and exhaustion on her limbs around the destruction, with her glazed eyes locking with Catra's one last time as if she was trying to speak all the words in the world in a simple gaze. And then she was surrounded by golden light and the smell of electrified magic so bright Catra had to close her eyes; so powerful that Catra was overwhelmed with dizziness and all that she could hear was the rush of magic and Adora's pained gaso. And when Catra opened her eyes again in the place where Adora was there was only fallen debris and a hovering goddess, a golden and white princess later known among the ranks as Sher-Ra standing with cold eyes and a sword coated with blood and Catra died at that moment too.

This woman, this *thing* , this specter of magic that killed Adora and later took Catra, *She-Ra,* she is not Adora. She is… sadder.

She is regal and golden, posture perfect, face blank. A perfect soldier of a blood soaked rebellion. The only times Catra has seen her after the wedding have been in the war room or in battle and even there she was spotless and powerful, not a single misstep or hesitation, eyes frozen in a single expression that is both calculating and void of hesitation and Catra can't stop thinking if she wore the same look the day she ripped Catra's Adora until there wasn't even a body for Catra to try and take back home before Lonnie dragged her screaming body back into the tanks.

But outside battle, she is different. She is quiet in every single meeting, crystal blue eyes glued to the holographic maps or the strategy charts placed in the walls. She speaks calmingly yet commanding, sure of what she means and what she plans but low enough still to be gentle. A kind of unearthly beautiful voice rolling out of her mouth every time she turns around to ask for Catra's opinion or plan, running a swift gaze over her before looking again. She always walks last and leaves first on every reunion, flanked by Queen Sparkles and Bow, silent even when they are speaking to her. She never eats in the dining hall and is always up at dawn. Catra has seen her from the tall pillars of the corridors,

sparring with holographic adversaries in the gardens. Catra can't sleep at night so she watches.

She is tender, with people, even when they stutter and step away from her, too mesmerizing by her presence, too overwhelmed by her existence. She visits the orphanages Catra has built across the towns and is soft with the children, sitting on the dirty floor and holding sticky tiny hands in her huge fingers. She never looks at Catra but when she does, *when she does* , when nobody else is watching, Catra can feel the burning blue of her gaze against her back and shoulders, unspoken tension, heavy words she guards inside of her and Catra hopes one day they'll choke her to death, her body shivering without her permission under the quickly hidden gaze.

She doesn't speak to Catra outside what is needed of them but she is always hovering near her, at empty fields of finished battle where the smoke lingers and the echoes of screams still hang in the air. In the war room, when the rest of the stupid princesses of the alliance throw heavy and angry looks at Catra as if the latter was still attacking them and not trying to help. Around destroyed towns where people remember Catra's face, the Horde’s commander, the unspoken Red Princess, and they turn away from her and hide or spit at her bare feet. Catra *knows* what she has done, she knows *why* she has done it and there are scars like lightning across her body as a payment to it. She doesn't need their dirty eyes and scowling lips. But there is She-Ra, always, lingering like another kind of shadow around Catra, silent like a curse.

She-Ra wears armor, not the worn out and warm red fabric of a jacket but golden everywhere, from the breastplate to the wrist gauntlets and the boots, golden stained on copper by dried blood when in battle. She wears white everywhere else, on her long sleeves and the soft fabric on her pants that is impenetrable by any weapon known of the Etheria’s kind. Starlight silver chainmail that twinkles and shimmers under the sharp edges of her golden chest plate, reflecting in the opals and rubies and sapphires of her

head piece. She is golden and all Catra can see on her is red and Catra hates her.

The first time Catra saw her, her hair was long, sun poured loops falling over her back as if the wind itself was cradling it. It was like this for a long time, for years coated in battle and more blood. She was a golden shadow every time Catra saw her, always in the far end of the battle lines, never facing Catra directly even when she became Commander and later Leader, always a coward. She was golden across lost and won fights throughout three years and then among the green shadow of Horde Prime's ships hovering over the new sky and under the golden lights of the small Brightmoon chapel where she took Catra's hand without looking at her, when the world was already wartorn and the danger of extermination choked them all in fear and neither of them were left without another choice.

Today, as she steps inside Catra's gilded cage, her hair is short as it has been since Catra moved into this rotten palace to negotiate the war, curling over her ears under the golden circle around her forehead. Today, her clothes are relaxed, high waisted pants and sleeveless shirt, marble white chest plate and forearm gauntlets and Catra knows she guards that cursed blood stained sword there, that she could unfolded it as she has done with the very same universe and slay Catra down yet in all her cruelty she doesn't. Today she is *looking* at Catra, fully, charged blue eyes like frozen lakes and parted mouth. She is still too bright, like one of the newfound stars shimmering on this new kind of sky. She is too bright and too beautiful and Catra *hates* her.

“Out,” Catra growls, digging her nails against her own palms until she feels burning hot pain and the flood of her own blood pooling on her fingers. “Get out”

“Catra,” She-Ra says, wincing almost imperceptibly at the sight of blood on Catra's fingers. “Please”

“Who the fuck do you think you are? Uh?” Catra drags every single word, running them through her tongue and spitting them

out of her sharp teeth, venom dripping out of her mouth like a fresh wound. She spins in her ankles, facing the princess fully, nails unshed and hair wild. “Do you think going around and offering yourself to go into dangerous fucking missions makes you a hero? That it will fix all the pain you've caused? To me?”

The reassuring hand She-Ra had risen stills in the air, her body freezing in the middle of the chamber, unmoving, face locking into an unreadable stare. She is tall, so tall, standing like this Catra can barely reach her collarbones, tall and strong in the way her muscles shift in her body when she gives a single step back. Tall and unapproachable, untouchable. Adora was just tall enough to rest her nose over Catra's forehead. Sometimes, if Catra closes her eyes at night in this fucked up cold bed, she can still feel her on her skin.

Catra narrows her eyes, sharp blue and amber flashing red. “Do you think you can boss me around? That you can tell me, *me,* what missions to go or not going to? That I am your property?”

“Of course not!” She-Ra exclaims and for a second the ring of her voice overlaps across the entire chamber, unnatural as everything in her. Catra has to fight down a flinch, her ears pressing without her permission against her head not because she is scared but because it takes her by surprise completely. She-Ra’s blazing blue eyes dim down, voice lowering and face blank as if she was ashamed to have raisen it to Catra in the first place. “Of course not. Catra, that's not why I asked you to stay in Brightmoon at the meeting.”

She-Ra huffs, breathless like she couldn't find the correct words to say, roaming her eyes from Catra to the room around them and the movement is so human it makes Catra want to scream.

“Mystacor is completely invaded by Horde Prime. It is hoarded by clones and the few sorcerers that couldn't escape are dead. There is nothing left of it, nothing. Just trying to go there to look for any clue of the Failsafe could be a death sentence,” She-Ra’s eyes snap back to Catra, looking at her as if she *knew her,* as if she

thought she could weave her way under Catra's skin and convince her of her words. “I vowed to protect you. I swore it when we… when I …”

The words leave her and she falls quiet but Catra understands enough. She steps back, chuckles, runs her claws through her own hair until the sharp tips draw blood in her scalp and the golden beads keeping it together give up and her hair spills below her work out mask. Pain keeps her focused, it keeps her sane, anything else to feel inside of what festers inside of her. She stares at She-Ra's pale face and lets out a loud cackle, void of any kind of mirth, cold and cutting that makes She-Ra’s perfect eyebrows twitch, breaking her unaprocheable facade for once.

“Oh come on. You can't possibly be that stupid. You cannot believe *I'm* that stupid,” Catra exclaims, voice high and squeaky, losing the grip on her own sanity. She can feel heat crawling on her cheeks and temples, a rageful fever clouding her eyes with treacherous tears that she doesn't allow to let fall. She-Ra does not speak anymore, her face guarded, as if every word that falls out of Catra's mouth was hurting her and that just makes her angrier, more violent. She steps up until she is almost completely in front of She-Ra, tilting her chin up, spitting the very same vows they had been forced to recite on that mock of a celebration. Vows that weren't supposed to be said to this unapproachable goddess but to a warm girl that is now dead. Vows that poisoned it all, all of this, Catra joined to Adora's killer. *“This is our pledge, one in flesh and in spirit. Blood of my blood, bone of my bone. And when death comes and seizes me by the throat, I'll hold your hand and breathe you life so you return home.* Please.”

Catra says the last word full of mock and fury, hoping it will humiliate her. She-Ra's face is casted down but she is holding Catra's eyes, an embarrassed flush breaking in her neck and cheeks. For the sit of a second she looks angry, shoulders tense under all that godforsaken gold. It makes Catra satisfied, knowing that she is able to make this soulless murderer feel *something,* even if it's anger.

She-Ra squares her back, holding Catra's furious eyes in hers, her long hands twitching at her sides. Catra can see the glimmer of the sword's blue jewel shivering on her bracer, illuminating the side of She-Ra's face into blue, like one of the goddess painted on the walls of the castle. “It meant something, Catra.”

“It didn't! You and I know why we went through it, why your *Queen* sent that proposition to the Horde that you couldn't even bring yourself to write by your own hand.” Catra is yelling now, shivering from head to toe. “The Horde and the Alliance can't attack each other as long as we are married. As long as we are married you cannot hurt my people anymore. *Those* people *your* kind sneered down to, and fought and made bleed, *I'm* the one that protects them.”

Catra never cared for the Horde. She was an orphan the moment she arrived there, as everyone else, ripped from their families arms and left to rot on that place like another object ready to be thrown into war. She knew what they did, she knew how they played with their minds and poisoned them and Catra could never care for any of it. But Adora cared, Adora wanted to make it right even before she realized everything was wrong to begin with. Adora cared for their cadet mates even though they were assholes; she cared for the Force Captains and all the big and small parts of their forces. She cared and so Catra cares now.

“Horde Prime does not care about who he kills or how. He slaughtered Hordak in front of all of us to prove a point. He kidnapped your Queen, he… to me, he…” Catra sucks a breath, her chest squeezing painfully as the memories flood her like a tsunami, green water and electricity; Adora's beautiful face stained in ash and blood inside her mind, She-Ra standing celestial over her grave. Loops of memories meant to drive her mad and Prime standing behind it all as he tortured her. Catra chokes with her breath, tears spill free down her cheeks and She-Ra's face crumbles but Catra doesn't even notice it.

“We are not winning without your princesses and your Alliance is not winning without my people. It's as simple as that. It's political,

it's convenient. So don't try to come and tell me it meant something for you when you have barely spared a look for me in years. Do not try to come and *pity me* for my pain. Not now that you feel guilty just because I'm flesh reminding you of what you've *done."* Catra never meant to say these words when she stormed out of the war chamber, she never meant for She-Ra to follow her here with low casted eyes and pale cheeks, but now that she is here Catra can't stop them all, falling out of her chest and into her palms and the floor like swords, meant to slash and hurt and open invisible wounds on She-Ra's impenetrable skin. " Those words? Those vows? They meant *nothing* to me! Nothing!"

She-Ra has gone quiet again. Even her breathing is so slow that it almost looks like she is not taking a breath at all. Her hands culs around her sides and relax again several times, eyes staring outside of the open window. She is so beautiful like this, unmoving in the middle of a room Catra will never be able to actually call hers. Beautiful and infuriating. Right now, Catra needs the storm, the anger, the blood. The fury.

"Look at me!" Catra demands with a scream, barely holding back the need to strike her in the face. "Say something!"

She-Ra returns her eyes to Catra immediately, heavy with unspoken emotions. She raises her hand as if she were to strike Catra and for a moment Catra's mind clouds with the memory of shadows choking her and mangling her every time Weaver wanted to keep her quiet or punish her. After all, both Weaver and She-Ra are monsters in Catra's story. But She-Ra doesn't. Instead, she runs her knuckles down Catra's cheek, feather soft barely even touching Catra's freckled skin. She does so *so* gently, her huge hand trembling when they touch, as if this monster that is so big on Catra's mind didn't know how to touch her right, like a piece of staining glass about to crack under silver steel, afraid to even hurt her.

"I'm sorry, Catra." she says, and it is so honest, so trembling voice breaking with hidden sadness, that it tears Catra's heart apart. "I never meant to cause you so much pain"

Catra could scream. She could grab the knife she keeps guarded under her pillows and throw herself against this bloodied warrior and run it across her chest until she is no more. She could turn around the blade and drag it over her own throat and be done with it. But she can't, she is rooted to this place to this moment, under the lilac light of the crystal lamps above their head and She-Ra's warm hand cradling her cheek, damp with cold tears.

“I despise you.” Catra says, strangled, broken around her teeth. It's true and a lie all at the same time, mangling whatever that is left of Catra’s mangled heart. She-Ra shrinks around herself, blue eyes breaking but she doesn't move away, taking all of Catra's poison inside of her, and so, Catra doesn't move away either. “I've fought you. I have made you bleed. I chased you when you turned your back to me. I opened a doomed portal because I would rather see the whole world burn down than let you win. I've been trying to rip you apart all of these years just so I could finally die too. And you *pity* me?” Catra slams her own hand against her chest, sharp claws catching on the fragile skin of her collarbones. She-Ra's unnatural blue pupils shrink at the sight. “Look what you've made of me! Look at what you've done to the world! Everyone believes you are a hero but I know what you are. This is all your fault!”

“I know,” She-Ra says, heavy, bent over as if the weight of the entire word was hanging over her shoulders; the weight of something else, completely unspoken, something beyond vows and strategy, red ribbons tying them together. So defeated, it tangles Catra's voice inside her vocal cords. “I know”

She-Ra's hand falls from Catra's face to her hair, thumbing the ends of a curl rebelling behind Catra's twitching ear. When she was younger, Catra had tuffs of gray hair below her ears, soft looking and striking against the dark of the rest of her curls. Adora used to curl her fingers over them at night when they were toddlers and the rumbling of the Fright Zone was still too scary to sleep. The motion stuck for years to come, Adora running her fingers over the gray strands when Catra's hair was tangled by the training, on the roof of the platform at sunset or at night, resting

with her mouth pressed over Catra's bare shoulder. After Adora's death, Catra snipped them off completely; she stood in front of the cracked mirror of her new room and cut them off with her nails until her scalp and the base of her ears were bleeding and the lonely strands coiled around her feet.

Right now, She-Ra touches her hair in a way that reminds her of Adora. Less sure, much more scared, but still gently. As if she was searching for the gray strands somewhere beyond Catra's fractured mask. Catra's skin rises into goosebumps, her heart hammering inside her chest, throat closing with something rotten sweet.

“I look after you. That's what I do” She-Ra whispers, still too bright, still too perfect, still too untouchable. Still too honest, words perfectly stabbing through Catra's mind. “Nothing bad is going to happen to you.”

Every single thought on Catra's mind stops. Even her heart inside her chest skips a beat, so strong that it might burst out of Catra's chest and bleed all over the floor. The words echo in her fine ears, pulling with them memories woven so deeply inside Catra's very soul that they turn around her entire world. She can still smell the old metal of the bed bunks where Adora made that first promise to her; she can feel the rough material of their childhood blanket and Adora's young-toddler faces all tooth gaps and dimples. Catra knows those words but this monster shouldn't and suddenly every single fragile strand holding her together snaps away.

“Who told you those words?” Catra whispers, teeth clicking with each other with how hard she is shaking. She-Ra's hand freezes but Catra is already beyond anything that is happening around her. All the air has been sucked out of the room, all the colors and the sounds until the only thing she can sense is She-Ra's magic crashing against her skin. “Where did you hear them?” she repeats, and when no sound comes out her eyes snap up, opal like under the like coming in front of her. “Answer to me!”

Catra is hyperventilating, her chest rising and falling with every elaborated breath. There are spots of black on the edge of her vision and a rumbling inside her ears, like the rush of the ocean crashing against her frail bones. She can feel She-Ra all around her, She-Ra and her sweet breath and the smell of her magic; the hesitant touch of her hand and the nasty, dark, rotten sweet feeling that stirred on Catra's heart when she offered herself to go into Mystacor alone. But underneath her closed eyelids, she can see Adora's face; her dumb smile, her wheat hair against Catra's fingers, her warm palm below her palm, the way her gray eyes were full of fear but also determination before falling into debris and the drops of her red blood against a blue blade.

"Catra. Catra –" She-Ra is calling for her, echoing as a hundred voices inside the heated room. She is holding Catra's shoulders as if the latter were to pass out suddenly, and maybe she would, if the rage in her lungs wasn't fueling her like an explosion about to go off.

"Don't touch me!" Catra screams suddenly, violently shaking She-Ra's hands away from her body, shuddering without her permission at the loss. Catra embraces herself, her claws drawing clear red lines against her sides where the fabric gives away, her skin screaming with the sudden pain. She-Ra's face is broken with worry but Catra doesn't care, she just doesn't *fucking care.* "Don't talk to me! Don't talk to me like you were her!"

Did Adora say those words? Did she plead them before dying at this woman's hand? Was Catra the last thing in her mind? Their fight? Their nights together? Their hands laced at their spot on the roof? Coming back to her?

Did She-Ra hear her beg for her life and still drew her ethereal sword against her because she wore the colors of the enemy? Did She-Ra do it without thinking that person, that beautiful, *beautiful* gray eyed person, was needed? That she was loved?

"I hate you!" Catra is screaming. Her voice sounds foreign, even to her ears, ringing like war horns. "I hate you, I hate you, I hate

you, I hate you, I hate you, I hate you!”

Catra doesn't know when she moved from where she was standing because now her hands are wrapped tightly around the collar of She-Ra's shirt, pulling from her until she hears the magical fabric rip, shaking her with the sheer violence of the pull. She-Ra lets her, completely surrounding herself to Catra's fury. She doesn't shake herself off Catra's hold even though she could do it so easily, like shaking a feather off her armor. They tether over the polished floor, barely avoiding a fall.

She-Ra digs her heels into the ground and holds them both up. She stares back at Catra's furious, heartbroken face – cheeks flushed, eyes swimming in tears, her head piece knocked over somewhere in the floor, all of her freckles pale and her ears tightly pressed against her head – and dares to speak. “I know”

Catra strikes her across the face. It's a slap, a claw of her hands. Her sharp nails catch She-Ra's starlight skin and rip down; lines of red like the ones of her own ribs painting above the bridge of She-Ra's nose and across her cheek. It must hurt, it *should* hurt; there is golden blood dripping down the curve of her cheek, falling against the back of Catra's hand, staining her in gold too. But She-Ra doesn't even flinch, taking the hit as she still tries to keep Catra's struggling body up. This is the closest they have ever been, outside of old battles where She-Ra contained herself to not touch Catra and the night in the woods when she caught Catra's bruised body inside her arms, left to die by Prime and barely even saved by She-Ra's magic. This is the warmest their bodies have been in a long time, chests pressed together, faces hovering over the other, Catra's hands on her face for another reason than a caress. She is so beautiful. Why is she so beautiful? Why has she torn Catra's world apart? Why can't Catra pull her out of her mind? She is beautiful. Why did she kill Adora? Beautiful, dead Adora. Catra strikes her again, and again, until her own hand is pulsing and tired and her eyes can't see past the blur of devastating crying making its way across her entire body.

“I hate you! You murdered her! You killed her! Why? Why did you do that? Why?!” Catra has gone breathless, voice sore and raw. She feels suddenly exhausted, bare to the bone and trembling. Her skin itches where it was wounded She-Ra, as if they shared the same wounds on two bodies, as if her very skin and soul was bleeding ichor too, done by her own hand. Catra is tired. “She only wanted to help all of you. She was good, she was so good. She was everything to me” Catra's voice breaks in the seams, melting around a gut wrenching sob, barely above a whisper like crystal brittle. “Why did you take her away from me? Why?”

She-Ra's arms wrap around her waist and shoulders, the wrist braces cold against the skin of her back, absorbing Catra's loud sobs inside the embrace as they wreck across Catra's entire body, breaking her down. She-Ra rests her nose against the base of Catra's ear, the steel smell of her magic enveloping Catra's entire body, her eyes closed tightly against the light. Catra can feel the way She-Ra presses her cold mouth over her hair, whispering the same words again and again, a string of another kind of vows. “I'm sorry, I'm so sorry”

Catra's knees give out and they sink together into the ground. She-Ra wraps her huge figure around Catra, covering her in gold and starlight, tangling their limbs together as Catra breaks down into pieces. Catra pushes her away, slamming her palm against She-Ra’s chest several times, chipping her nails against the hard gold. And then she tangles her fingers over She-Ra's neck and pulls her closer to her, pressing herself as close as she can to this ethereal body, seeking for the touch of her hands on every inch of her skin, the brush of her short hair around her fingers, the drum of her immortal heart against Catra's ribs.

Because the truth is, She-Ra has ruined Catra. Catra can't close her eyes without looking at She-Ra's face beneath her eyelids. She can't walk around these lilac halls or blooming gardens without feeling her blue eyes on her back and the nape of her neck, gazing Catra's steps across the cold palace. Catra can smell the lightning of her magic across the wrecked battlefields, wrapping around Catra's silhouette, following her through blood

soaked grass and red clouded sky. She can feel the touch of her sword-worn hand hovering above the low of her back when Catra stumbles around memories, when the walls of the war rooms with its maps and its princesses close too tightly around Catra's throat. She can smell the sweet breath of She-Ra's mouth next to her cheeks when she vow marriage to Catra. Can feel the squeeze of her fingers around her wrists when the lost king knotted their hands together and Catra was trembling so hard only this monster's steady hand kept her upright.

Catra can feel the sudden panic, cutting cold and lava-like, running down her own veins as She-Ra offered herself in the war room to go into Mystacor alone. A place where she could die, where Prime could catch her and rip her apart like he did to Catra; where she could face undeniable pain and torture. Where this undefeated goddess could breathe for the last time and nobody would be there to hold her hand. And instead of making Catra happy, or relieved, or surrounded by some kind of sick sense of justice for what She-Ra had done, it made Catra want to throw up. It made her want to throw herself off the highest towers of the castle; made her want to tear her heart out of her bare chest and place the beating organ still bleeding on She-Ra's hands as long as that would make her *stay.*

She-Ra holds Catra now with all the desperation of a repentant sinner, with the tenderness of a strained lover, with the promise of a gentle killer. Poisoned love, hatred venom. Starlight melting into Catra's feverish skin, crystal blue eyes making their way into Catra's broken string chords. A fallen star that murdered the sun of Catra's world. A lost soul that stole Catra, like Hades stole Persephone from the spring ground into a gilded inferno fuelled by want. By being tender and brave. By desire. Red strings falling from She-Ra's pale fingers and wrapping around Catra's throat. How dare she want to go and die in war when she should die by Catra's hand? How dare she try to go alone when all that is left of Catra is now hers? Catra wants to tear her to pieces. Catra wants to cradle her inside her chest, next to her lungs, beneath her ribs, slipping in the cracks of her heart where the last of Adora lives, and Catra knows that she has lost it all completely.

She-Ra has made Catra betray Adora, and she will never hate her as much as she hates herself for that.

“I'm in love with you. I love you.” Catra confesses into the quiet night filled by tears, against porcelain cheeks and golden wrists. Rotten sweet, meant to doom them both. “I love you. I wish you were dead”

Words that were meant for Adora and that now Catra says to her executioner and maybe, just maybe, Catra is dead too.

She-Ra stills below Catra's sharp hold, her chest freezing, her lips cold where they brush against the fine fur of Catra's ears. She might reject Catra, push her away, curse at her even. She might stand up and let Catra tumble against the cold floor, step with her golden soles across the room and close the heavy door behind her and never look back again. After all, this is fucked up, this thing boiling under Catra's skin it's rotten and unhealthy, festering like a curse and not something beautiful. Nobody would want it– *and the only person that ever wanted, desired, Catra and that Catra adored in return is gone now … …* Not when the woman below her hands could have anyone, anyone she ever wanted; when she could walk outside in all her star-like glory and be loved, desired; when she could take anyone else as a lover takes another. Someone so much more beautiful, someone less broken, someone that doesn't open your skin at the touch and then pulls you close. Someone that doesn't blame you, doesn't hate you at the same time she loves you. Someone that doesn't feel like drinking poison or crushing your head against a mirror; that's what Catra is now, that's what she will ever be until she is finally dead and nobody would ever want that. Nobody would *love* it. And things that are born from pity are never real, so why would this be different?

Maybe Catra doesn't want it to be different. Maybe Catra wants it to *hurt.* Maybe she thinks that the rejection of the other creature Catra has ever wanted will finally break her enough to make her stop *feeling* , to stop feeling *this.* Because that's the only thing Catra *deserves.* Loneliness and pain.

Catra is so focused trying to butcher herself with her own thoughts that she doesn't notice She-Ra shifting their positions. Her big hands come from being wrapped around Catra's back to the base of her head, cradling Catra's head as the warrior motions her gently but firmly to part from her dead grip hold and look at She-Ra's sharp blue eyes.

Catra thinks she will find anger in those eyes; disgust, *pity* even. But inside She-Ra's bright eyes there is only quiet desperation, held back only by some kind of inhumane force. Inside her eyes there is intelligence but also *desire,* her pupils blown wife as white new moons, her nostrils flaring, the curve of her perfect lips twitching as if she were to sob or scream. And for the first time in years, Catra thinks she is not the only one holding herself from *wanting.*

It would be a lie to say who moved first. It was Catra, fuelled by desperation, by love drenched in hate. It was She-Ra, filled to the brim with want poisoned in guilt. It was both of them, a liar and a sinner, soulmates knotted together by red strings they can't see over fear.

She-Ra tastes like lightning, cracking in Catra's lips, sizzling golden against her tongue when she coos her mouth open with her lips. She-Ra tastes like magic but also sweeter when she runs the flat of her tongue against the roof of Catra's mouth and Catra whimpers around her teeth, her claws catching on the short strands of golden hair and pulling her *in.*

She-Ra is huge around Catra's form, her hands wrapping almost completely around Catra's waist when she drags her palms under Catra's shirt, feeling her warm skin against hers. There are calluses on She-Ra's fingers, something so *human* in her otherwise ethereal body that they bring out an exhale out of Catra's mouth, melting into pieces when She-Ra caresses her with them against the soft bumps of her spine, touching her, learning her, eating her alive.

The air is humid inside the chamber, damp warm in the space that their bodies share, the brush of their clothes, their mouths and their skins caressing against each other. A breeze of cold air makes its way inside through the open balcony, hitting the bare skin if Catra's back and the sheer feeling makes her body jolt, biting into She-Ra's lips sharply, bruising, drawing ichor blood and taming the sting of pain right after. She-Ra hisses around the bite and for a moment she stops moving. Catra's heart skyrockets, not ready to face the reality of what is happening, tangling her fingers around her hair with desperation, for a second ready to cry and scream and plead her to stay; but she doesn't need to.

She-Ra surges again, kissing Catra in a way that makes every single thought come to a halt and her body to flare into flames, all velvet tongue and biting perfect teeth against her mouth and face, stealing the very air off Catra's lungs. Catra has never been kissed like this, with so much desperation, so much desire that it makes her mind tilt over into clouded heat and her limbs to tremble with want. Taken, devoured completely.

She has been kissed tenderly, shy, full of underlaid adoration, on stolen thin blankets next to boiler rooms, the happiest moments in her entire life, the love of her life. That is sacred, guarded inside Catra's heart like the pillars of her life.

This is different, urgent, kisses laid against bruised mouths in a way that make Catra squirm and shiver; being pressed off the cold floor and into soft sheets and magic air. Where She-Ra is kind, Catra is violent. She-Ra runs kisses on her wrists and Catra pulls from her hair harshly. Catra runs her claws down her back until she smells blood and She-Ra presses her mouth against her again, with all the passion of a new found lover.

Catra racks her nails over the solid gold in She-Ra's shoulders and it dissolves like mist between her fingers, leaving only printing white fabric and stardust scattered collarbones. Catra's shirt wrinkles around her ribs blades uncomfortable, and she wouldn't pay mind to it if it wasn't for the hand that roams down the center of her belly and then *pushed down* , locking her in place as She-

Ra sucks on her tongue and places a trail of heated kisses down her bone jaw. Catra growls around a whimper, scrambling into a sitting position as best as she can before thumbing the small buttons of the straps of the shirt, freeing them as she grabs the handful of fabric and pulls it completely away from her.

Catra's body is battered in war scars, done by battles of by her own hand, patches of skin where the flesh is crooked and raised pink, nothing beautiful to see or touch. Without her shirt, her torso is bare, free of any kind of undergarment and Catra can feel the delicate skin of her breasts shivering by something completely different than the cold. She-Ra gasps around Catra's mouth, her head falling against Catra's neck, the golden diadem cold and her panting boiling hot where their skins meet. Is obvious she is trying not to look but her hands betray her, barely brushing underneath the soft sweet of Catra's breasts before stilling completely once again, frozen in place.

Catra seaks for her sparkling mouth again, blindly, running her nose across She-Ra's ear shell and down her flushed cheekbone before finding her bruised lips, drowning them both into another damp kiss. She-Ra groans around Catra's tongue and the sound vibrates down her throat in a way that tilts Catra off the edge of reason, arching her back against the bed with a long, uncontained moan.

It's long, high pitched, in heat; it's her mind melting and her heart on shambless, body bare to give. It should ashame Catra, as everything she is doing right now, but under the ring of the sound She-Ra's body twitches and her hips jolt, up and then *down* between Catra's, eliciting sparks of pleasure on both of them, crossing them like swords. She-Ra shivers again and this time she does pull away from Catra's hold around her neck and face, just enough so she can murmur around Catra's cheeks .

“Catra, wait. Catra” She-Ra's voice is *broken,* sore and raw like a new bloom under frost.

She is shaking her head but at the same time her body is betraying her around Catra's touch, seeking for Catra's body like a planet to the sun. Catra's eyes are clouded underneath the goddess, barely listening to the request when her legs twitch again and her hips move forward desperately, seeking for the blessed touch once again. Catra can see herself reflected on She-Ra's blue eyes; hair tousled, free of any braid or silver clip, curling around her face and ears in damp curls; her neck has been devoured, purple and red blooms like pomegranate stains down the column of her neck and the angle of her jaw; her face is completely flushed, from the collarbones to the cheeks, sweat clinging to her freckled skin; her own eyes are unfocused, staring back at the golden light nestled above her; and her mouth is partially open, lips bruised by magical kisses, panting heavily as She-Ra's saliva lingers on the tip of her tongue. Catra has never looked at herself like this before, this is new, terribly, murderously new. She looks at herself and doesn't know who she is, doesn't recognize herself, but her body seems to know because she holds herself to She-Ra's sweaty neck and rock herself against her belly, over the thin magical fabric of her sleeveless shirt once, just once, and Catra *moans* again, a sound never made out of her before that stitches itself inside both of them for eternity.

She-Ra holds her breath, pupils dilating so much the white overtakes the blue completely, her hands already roaming down the sides of Catra's shivering chest before she stops herself again, closing her eyes so tight it must hurt before opening them again. She-Ra's hands stop, palms resting at either side of Catra's head, over the sheets and away from her skin. Her body stills and her breath even as much as it can, hovering her body above Catra's without touching her anymore. She is unmoving but her shoulders are shaking uncontrollably, clear to the view after most of the golden armor is gone by some kind of ethereal command. It looks like it hurts; like being away from Catra, even through these small inches, is causing her the worst pain possible but she does it, bringing Catra's mind back into reality.

“Wait” She-Ra repeats, steady, still gently but just on the edge of commanding. Catra’s body stills too, hammering heartbeat

fluttering to a stop. Her ears press down her head and her face pales, rejection and fury making their way acid down her veins. She-Ra must see it – she somehow seems to see everything about Catra - because the next time she speaks is gentler, eyebrows twitching with pleading concern. Perfect General She-Ra of the Alliance, Commander of legions, Bringer of magic, Horde Slayer, stumbling with her words for the first time around the warm hands of a war-torn magicat. “Please wait. I– I can't touch you, not like this.”

Catra should have expected it but it still stings, slaying her wide open on this sweet space that once was meant to be their wedding bed. Her teeth click together when she closes her mouth with a snap, fang catching in her own lip and making her bleed.

“Why?” Catra questions, cringing at the way it comes as a plea, broken into pieces. She-Ra's eyes break too at the sound of Catra's cracked voice but Catra speaks again before her, this time anger clear as water. “You, hypocrite. Am I not your wife?”

“You are,” She-Ra says, sure and tender. She is wrecked too; her golden circlet crooked, her golden hair messed up by Catra's desperate hands, there are kisses painted on her face and collarbones and her skin is peach flushed, a gentle contrast to pristine porcelain. Still not touching Catra, still away.

I've done it before. I was loved before, Catra wants to scream again, *that doesn't belong to you. It will always belong to her*, Catra wants to tear it out of her heart, herself and this love that is poisoning her, *everything else of me that is not rotten you can have it if you want it.*

“Don't you want me?” Catra asks instead, curling her hands over her own chest. She feels too bare suddenly, to open to the night. Everything that was hers to call was gone once she set foot on Brightmoon palace; the discarded shirt, the new version of her knocked out piece, the legging still clinging to her legs, they are all Brightmoon given. All that Catra has to offer is this, this

battered body and heartbroken soul; this hate and this resentment; this expiation and this love. Nothing else.

She-Ra moves this time, just one of her hands, holding the rest of her weight with the other one only. She grabs the edge of one of the rumpled blankets and lays it over Catra's bare chest without even looking at her exposed skin, sheltering from the outside. Then she runs her cold fingers through Catra's sweaty bangs, brushing them out of her face gently, barely touching her forehead at all. Catra's got a fever, brought up by fury and kisses, and the heated skin makes the corner of She-Ra's eyes narrow sadly.

“I do want you,” She-Ra whispers, cradling Catra's cheek inside her palm, thumbing the tears that Catra hadn't even noticed had started to run off her eyes. Catra wants to rip her away from her and she also wants to never let her go.

“Then? What else do you want from me?” Catra digs her sharp fingers over She-Ra's shoulder blades painfully. “I *love you.* I love you.” Catra mourns, letting herself bleed open. “You've tainted me. Might as well do it properly.”

“No, Catra. No like this.” She-Ra shakes her head, the saddest of smiles making its way on her mouth before dissolving completely. “Not when you are in pain,” she could kiss Catra again, she is so close, breathes mingling, but she doesn't. Maybe she does love Catra in return, after all. “I'd rather never touch you again than to cause you more suffering.”

Catra sobs, openly, her chest heavy and painful with each sore breath, as if she had just been stabbed through by She-Ra's hands and she could do nothing else but lay there and wait to die. She slams her palms against She-Ra's chest several times, seeking to make her feel pain too, but she is worn to the bone, she can't do it anymore, so Catra just sobs. It chokes her and for a moment Catra is scared, unable to breath or to ask for help. She presses her hands over the base of her own throat and whimpers, sad, void of any kind of previous heat, just sadness and mourning.

She-Ra wraps her warm hand around Catra's thin wrists and pulls down from them, softly, just enough so she can tangle their limbs together again. She-Ra wraps Catra's trembling body in her arms, her body pushing down Catra's subduing the way she convulses painfully with each cry, absorbing inside her golden body all of the sadness pouring out of Catra as a fresh wound that will never heal.

Catra rests her own freezing cold hands at the base of She-Ra's neck, keeping her close with steel grip. What would Adora think of Catra now, if she saw her in the arms of the person that killed her? Would she be angry? Disappointed? Sad? Would she hate Catra for what she is doing, for *who* she has given herself after her death? No, she wouldn't. Adora would be content, this Catra knows, she would be happy that Catra is not alone in this wretched world; no matter who, no matter what that very same person had done to her, Adora would be happy *for* Catra. *Go on,* she would say, *be happy my love. I am already gone.* That's how much Adora loved her.

"I'm going to kill you, at the end of this," Catra says next to She-Ra's ear, trembling and charged with the truth. Not tonight, not tomorrow, but at the end of the war when Etheria is free. It's a promise Catra makes to Adora, a silent prayer to wherever she is now, and Catra won't break it, not this one. "I'm going to kill you for what you did to her. You know that right?"

"I know" She-Ra whispers back, nestling her mouth against the point of Catra's neck where Prime' scars live.

"Are you going to stop me?" *Yes,* Catra hopes she'll say; that she'll make it easier this way. Catra hopes She-Ra will say that she will fight her, that she won't doubt to slice Catra's throat open when the time comes, that she will fight for her life. That it is not worth dying for Catra.

But instead, She-Ra whispers, "No" and "My life is yours. If anyone has the right over it, it's you Catra. To end as you wish"

Catra kisses her again, all damp tears and blood in her mouth, running tongue and gasps. She-Ra kisses her again slowly, with purpose, drinking off Catra's pain and bruised love until Catra is drowsy underneath her, lulled by exhaustion and She-Ra's body pressed against hers. Lips brushing and cheeks caressed, a shared secret in this war wrenched world, strained lovers and choked secrets. Kisses like promises and drunk poison and a love that might save or destroy it all in the end.



It's very late by the time She-Ra stumbles into the stables. The night moon illuminates everything outside in a tender shade of purple, yet She-Ra in all her golden light, trips several times almost crashing into the ground.

Her body aches, screams even, and for a long moment she didn't even know if she was going to be able to hold it back for longer, straining herself impossible further until she was biting back a cry from the pain. She almost slipped, two times, almost lost control completely and let go, drowning herself in the taste of Catra's precious mouth.

There are a few horses inside the stables, already asleep in their warm spaces, adults and younglings all the same, the sound of their heavy breathing falling over She-Ra completely. She holds herself to the wood pillars of the building, breathing slowly through her nose as golden light starts surrounding her from the inside out, stabbing through her limbs and skin and very bones, stardust falling out of her body in ribbons of gold.

Golden strands melt into wheat hair; bright blue eyes shimmer down into silver gray, ethereal to tender; porcelain skin smooth and untouched shimmering into a honeyed body, covered in old and new scars. Bones and muscles pull and shrink down, lowering her in height. Still strong arms, still wide back, but not unbreakable anymore. Transforming into something well known, something so much more vulnerable, something so much more

human. A goddess to a young woman that carries the entire weight of the world. Pain glaring on every single inch of her body, following her everywhere she goes for almost four years now. Drowning her, choking her, tearing apart her soul.

Adora doesn't remember a time when she wasn't in pain.

Adora trips across the stables until she reached the very back, on the left side where the wall has been opened to let the night breeze come through and the sight of the sleeping woods reflect inside. Swift Wind is resting over the soft hay on the ground, his white and pink body curled over himself, wings folded and resting at his sides. He's is calm but not sleeping, waiting silently. Adora knows just how much he hated being in the stables, feeling caged and trapped on the wooden walls yet he is always here at night, veiling for Adora's return from the castle because he knows this is the only place where she can rest.

Swift Wind raises his head from the floor in time to see Adora walk inside the stables with unsure steps, letting herself fall against the hay with a deep groan. Her body is covered in cold sweat, sticking the fabric of her shirt where she rests her back against the pegasus's side. Her body has given out completely on her, exhausted after holding She-Ra for so long without taking a break, making her tremble from head to toe so violently her teeth click with each other.

Where She-Ra is untouchable, Adora carries all of her battle wounds. Old a new. Blaster pointed, swords ends, scratches, bruises and falls. Pink and red and white, raised on her skin is a way that sometimes makes her want to cry. Because after all, She-Ra and Adora are one and the same and Adora is still human, even if nobody knows that.

Catra's wounds sting on her face and back, sizzling into a slow healing, lines of white gold and silver forever stitched into Adora's body now too. Adora rests the back of her head against Swift Wind and cover her eyes with her trembling palm, finally letting

go of the knot inside her throat and dissolving into a long, heartbreaking, cry.

Sobs rip across her entire chest as she cries silently on the cold floor of the stable, tears rolling down her cheeks and polling into her chin, dripping against her lap like quiet confessions. There is so much pain in Adora's body but nothing compares to this. This image that lives below Adora's closed eyelids, lean body, sea glass eyes, tears imon freckles; this smell lingering to her skin, a scent that Adora has known her entire life and that now is back; this touch that remains on the curve of her cheekbone and the low of her back, sharp nails and warm palms; this voice that is woven on the strings of Adora's heart, the only music she ever knew on the Horde and that she didn't know how to shelter from pain.

This person, Catra, Adora's Catra, who Adora has never known how to protect. She is so frail underneath She-Ra's hands, so full of fury and sorrow, so drowned in misery. She is strong yet thin, thinner than Adora had ever seen her, with the delicate bones of her wrists and the lilac bruises under her beautiful, dim eyes. She is always wearing black, no other color adorning her body, no flush on her face, perpetually mourning, dead in life. She is closed up on herself, she doesn't laugh, doesn't joke, doesn't chase. Adora doesn't remember the last time she saw her smile, with the kind of grin that split her face like the sun among poisoned air. She is covered in scars too, she is broken too. She is still in love with Adora, she is in love with She-Ra. She is lost and Adora cannot reach her in the darkness, just hold fast to her trembling body and pray for her life and shelter her of what is to come.

Swift Wind lets his wing fall over Adora, cradling her into the warm space below his feathers as he tilts his big head to the side, nudging Adora's cheek gently into the best kind of reassuring he can provide.

“You need to tell her the truth, Adora” Swift Winds whispers, charged with all the worry of a friend watching their loved one tear herself to pieces.

“I can't” Adora shakes her head, still covering her eyes with her hand; there are scars on her palms where she cut herself by accident with the sword the first time she transformed in Thaymor. When she speaks her voice is not ethereal and unearthly but worn and splintered. “I can't Swifty.”

“But you are suffering. And she is suffering too” Swifty rests his head over Adora's shivering shoulder, “What's the point?”

The truth is, Adora doesn't plan to survive this war.

She has been fighting for so long that the only thing she knows now is the brush of the sword against her palm, the sound of flesh ripping open, blood spraying on her face. She has been mangled, punched, shoved, stabbed, hurt; and later Adora bled all of She-Ra's wounds into the floor. She has been sacrificed, had been stolen and thrown to the wolves to eat her flesh as they wanted. Weaver, Light Hope, even the Alliance, all of them the same. She has been used as a weapon, been *turned* into a weapon, stripping everything tender and sweet out of her until there was only battle and loss and impending doom. Adora has been assassinated in ways that had nothing to do with physical death until she didn't know who she really was anymore. Until there was only She-Ra and everything that it was Adora lived only inside Catra, at the other side of the war, on the opposite side of the world.

Catra already lost Adora. She mourned her, she still does. She cried on an empty tomb and placed wildflowers on the cold earth. Adora can't do the same thing to her, not again. Catra might mourn She-Ra when she is gone, but in her mind Adora will have been made justice. And eventually, hopefully, she'll be able to move on and *live.* Be happy again. Fall in love again, even if it's not Adora. She will live and grow old in a world Adora will free *for her,* where the air is not poisonous and flowers bloom in the ground, where the morning moon is silver and the sky is scattered in stars, and Adora will be able to rest knowing she will be safe.

There is no future for Adora, but Catra will have one.

Adora never meant to get so close again but this is Catra, *Catra,* beautiful, angry, uncontainable Catra. And even in her grief and her thirst for She-Ra's blood in Adora's name, the echo of Catra's love for Adora that now mirrors in She-Ra was too strong for both of them to resist. A force that pulls them back together, layered in guilt and pointing fingers, covered in kisses and palms against skins. And Adora, hidden under the starlight skin and golden light, Adora who has loved Catra entire life with her entire heart, was too weak to hold back, to keep her away. Adora who was too tender. Adora who can't understand yet that Catra loves She-Ra because, after all, She-Ra *is* Adora. Even if Catra doesn't know it, even beyond Catra's instincts, and hatred, and revenge, Catra has fallen in love with her all over again, with another version of her that is sadder and so much more burdened. Adora who kissed Catra again after years of pain, who ran her finger over her hair and covered her bare body from the cold and the pain. Adora who will give herself to Catra in every way possible. Adora who missed her too much.

Adora's greatest selfishness in a world that had striped everything out of her, the smell of Catra's breath against her mouth.

Adora never meant to hurt her like this, to do something that would slowly murder them both in different ways but she had no choice, *she didn't have another choice.* The image of Catra's limp, broken body laying in blood stained grass on the Whispered Woods will haunt Adora for whatever that is left of her life. Outside of the world's safety, and the Horde and the Alliance, Adora knows Horde Prime will hunt Catra again as soon as he finds her alone; as soon as he realizes Catra *means* something to She-Ra, if he doesn't know already. It was a warning, after all, Catra's broken body on the Whispering Words, a warning and a promise *I will find what you love the most and I will tear it apart whenever I want.* He will break her, completely, and Adora would rather carry the world across the universe again and butcher him from the inside out, before letting him near her again.

This was the only way, *the only way* for the Alliance to promise to protect her, to shelter her, even after everything, after all the war

and the hatred for Catra festering among the Court. Even after She-Ra is gone. That was the deal, that was what Adora made Glimmer promise on the quiet solitude of the Queen's quarters, the very same night she begged for the Horde's help in the search of freedom. Catra's safety, the promise of a future.

She-Ra marrying Catra was her greatest act of loyalty.

Adora living for Catra will be her greatest act of love. But she doesn't know that yet.

Adora rests her head against Swift Wind's side and turns her sore eyes towards the open wall of the stable, staring at the quiet castle's doors and then beyond, past the halls and the gardens and up the highest of towers, where She-Ra left her heart sleeping on tears-dampened blankets, not so different to the rough fabric of the Horde's where they cried too as children. Where She-Ra brushed Catra's bangs from her tormented face and healed her rageful fever with magic touch. Where She-Ra sat on the floor next to Catra's sleeping body and veiled for her nightmare fuelled sleep without daring to touch the bare skin of her shoulder. Where She-Ra traced Catra's open palms with quiet finger tips, small scarred hands against starlight bloodstained ones.

Where Adora leaned towards Catra and pressed a lingering kiss on her temples – *sweet, mournful, full of regret and pain* – before leaving the room, before she could wake up, before she could know the truth. Where Adora whispered *I love you too* against the cold side of the closed door, words drowned in the darkness of the hallway where it could its only find solace.

Catra sleeps on Brightmoon's tower, on She-Ra's chamber, on She-Ra's empty bed. Catra still smells like Adora, scents bounded together even after so many years, clean soap and sandalwood and the ghost of memories. She dreams of Adora and in her dreams Adora smiles before being swallowed by golden light. In her dreams she cradles Adora's face between her palms and then she blinks and it is not Adora's precious face at all but She-Ra's,

beautiful and full of sorrow, leaning to kiss the bridge of her nose in a way Catra knows by heart. And still, Catra doesn't know.

Adora sits on the cold floor of the stables and doesn't sleep. Swift Wind covers her with his wings to keep her warm and he says nothing else, silently mourning his friend. Adora remains here and nobody knows it. Adora mourns here and nobody knows who she is, not even herself. She closes her eyes and sees Catra's sea glass eyes, full of fire and as beautiful as the last time *Adora* saw them, worried under the dim light of Thaymor. Adora thinks of her hair curling above her ears in loops and she mourns the gray strands that framed her jaw, wonders what happened to them, wonders just how deep Catra's despair runs and Adora hates herself for it.

Adora thinks of her hands, the way she knows Catra’s pain through her hands trembling and scattered in scars; the way her hand was warm when She-Ra vowed marriage to her and Catra didn't know it was actually Adora, promising all her devotion to her, all that is left of her life, everything absolutely everything Adora, *She-Ra* , has to give. All of it it's Catra's.

She thinks in all the ways *Adora* has died, in the way she is alive because Catra is alive too, in all the ways Adora would go through hell again and again just for the privilege of being in love with her.

Night runs them by and they love each other, they die for each other. And they are a whole world apart.



What I had left here, I just held it tight

So someone with your eyes, might come in time

To hold me like water, or Christ, hold me like a knife

– *Who we are,* **Hozier**

End Notes

A few needed notes:
*Catra and Adora's relationship on the Horde is different from the show, here they were already in love which makes Adora's loss even more heartbreaking and devastating for Catra
*Nobody knows She-Ra's identity as Adora besides Bow and Glimmer, who were in Thaymor too. They think it's best to not bring a Horde soldier so they present She-Ra as the lost warrior that has come back to help Etheria. This only fuels Catra with more rage when she demands knowing what happened to Adora in the Battle of Brightmoon and nobody even knows who that is
*Catra and Adora's (as She-Ra) interactions from season 1 to 4 are extremely different. She-Ra tries to talk Catra into joining the Alliance at first but Catra almost kills her in rage "therefore the words 'I have made you bleed'. And in later battles She-Ra refuses to fight Catra so as to not hurt her more. After all, Adora is deeply in love with her and even with everything Catra is doing, she can't bear to raise a single finger against her.
*The blood on She-Ra's sword in Thaymor that led to Catra thinking Adora is dead was an accident. Adora cut her palms with the sword when she grabbed it by the blade in a panic, as she didn't know what was going on
*Adora has much more control of She-Ra than in canon given 1) she trains with Razz instead of Light Hope and 2) she bases all her self control and stability on using She-Ra to protect Catra, even from the Alliance.
*Catra does pull the level of the portal but she does so thinking that way she can get Adora back even for a few moments before the world breaks. Which works until Adora starts to remember and slips out of her fingers again. This is a parallel of Angela and Micah reuniting in the portal and later losing each other again without knowing Micah is alive. Catra and Adora do not have a confrontation in this universe and when Catra thinks Adora has been swallowed by the portal

she lets herself fall into the abyss to try and join her which breaks Adora even more.
*Catra does end up running the Horde instead of Hordak and she a harsh and cold but also a much kinder leader, as she takes on her mission to care for the people of the Horde just as Adora wanted before ‘dying’ even tho she is losing her marbles at the end
*Catra's wish to avenge Adora by offing She-Ra is stronger than her wish to die
*Adora breaks Light Hope and the Crystal Castle instead of the sword to bring Etheria out of Despondos.
*Horde Prime executes Hordak for treason and for the giggles ¯_(ツ)_/¯ sorry
*Horde Prime does kidnap Catra and Glimmer but the events are different and Save the Cat doesn't happen the same way. Glimmer and Catra form a makeshift friendship. Glimmer is interrogated much harsher where Prime can actually see into her memories without her noticing
*The whereabouts of Shadow Weaver are unknown (to you)
*Catra helps Glimmer escape (directly into Etheria, Bow, She-Ra and Entrapta don't travel to space) and she is tortured in the green pools but not chipped (he uses the memories of Adora and the memory of She-Ra supposedly when she killed her to almost drive her mad)
*Prime ends up sending her back as a emotional and physiological torture directly into She-Ra's hold, who heals her (Prime knows Adora is alive and She-Ra as he saw it on Glimmer's memories and plans to use Catra rage so she kills her herself)
*Full of rage for what Prime did to Catra, Adora actually kills entire squadrons of Prime's clones in cold-blood and raises a magic barrier between Prime and Etheria, which manages to buy them time. Is on the time between this that they come up with the plan of joining the Horde and the Alliance to defeat him.
*Marriage is the strongest alliance of them all which is why She-Ra (the Alliance representative) and Catra (Horde leader) are set to marry. No married kingdoms can attack each other.

*Before the wedding Adora makes Glimmer promise she and Bow will look out for Catra after the war and no matter what, as Adora knows the Alliance might try to trial her and punish her for her years leading the Horde
*Micah marries She-Ra and Catra.
*As much as Catra hates She-Ra, it is impossible for her not to fall in love. Even in the years of war she always was pulled to her for something different than rage. She doesn't know that she has fallen in love with another side of Adora
*Adora chooses not to reveal her identity after the wedding to protect Catra from
*Melog and Krytis haven't happened yet.
*Prime does chip people but he is much more vile here. He will kill.
*By this point, they know about the Failsafe but have no idea where to look. An anonymous tip sends them towards Mystacor and She-Ra offers to go alone (as she can blend in as Adora if she is alone). The place is swarmed by Prime's clones. When Catra says she'll go too, She-Ra panics and shuts her down (hence the beginning of this chapter)

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